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Reducing lanes for cars doesn't slow 911 response

Posted on July 22, 2024 (<https://ssti.us/2024/07/22/reducing-lanes-for-cars-doesnt-slow-911-response/>)



By Megan Link

Road diets, for example, converting 4 lanes into 3, provide many benefits including traffic calming and improved safety for drivers, bicyclists, and pedestrians. Agencies implementing road diets have seen a 29% average reduction in crashes. However, they often face pushback when planning these conversions, especially from those concerned about potential delays for emergency response. New research suggests these conversions don't delay emergency response vehicles, meaning they could offer a more balanced approach to safety.

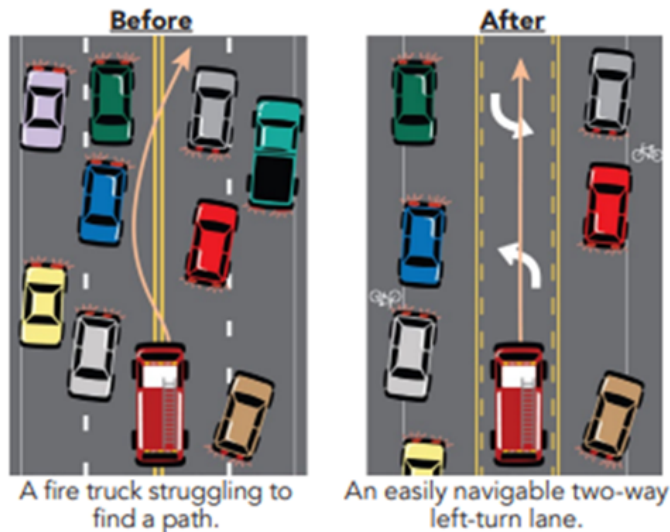
An analysis of emergency response teams in Iowa, one of the pioneering states in implementing road diets, found that they did not significantly affect emergency response times. The [study](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.trip.2024.101158) (<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.trip.2024.101158>) evaluates perceptions and response rates of emergency teams following the introduction of road diets. Results indicate that ¾ of segments analyzed showed minimal changes in response rates after a road diet, despite varying perceptions of the road diet's impact among emergency responders.

Not all emergency responders agree, according to the study, but more than half felt either neutral or positive about road diets. Among EMS drivers, 34% preferred the road diet conversion, 50% felt neutral, and 14% chose to avoid converted streets.

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Driver yielding behavior was the most common cause of negative feedback. Educating drivers on proper yielding in areas with road diets could mitigate such issues, according to the researchers.



FHWA instructional guide on how drivers should yield in road diet. Drivers should yield on the side of the road instead of in the middle lane. Source: FHWA

In an effort to “debunk the myths” about road diets, a [fact sheet](https://safety.fhwa.dot.gov/road_diets/resources/pdf/fhwasa17021.pdf) (https://safety.fhwa.dot.gov/road_diets/resources/pdf/fhwasa17021.pdf) from FHWA says they can “significantly improve response times by allowing emergency vehicles to bypass traffic” while “reducing motor-vehicle crashes by 19 to 47 percent [...] A road diet design opens a more predictable and practical path for emergency responders.” The resource cites [case studies](https://rosap.ntl.bts.gov/view/dot/50488) (<https://rosap.ntl.bts.gov/view/dot/50488>) where road diets improved EMS response times.

Other roadway changes face similar scrutiny regarding their impact on emergency response. During COVID, London implemented several low-traffic neighborhoods, areas that restrict vehicles in residential areas to improve walking and biking safety. An [analysis](https://findingspress.org/article/23568-the-impact-of-2020-low-traffic-neighbourhoods-on-fire-service-emergency-response-times-in-london-uk) (<https://findingspress.org/article/23568-the-impact-of-2020-low-traffic-neighbourhoods-on-fire-service-emergency-response-times-in-london-uk>) found no significant change in response times. Response teams that reported a “delay due to traffic calming” also found that these delays were offset by delays outside of the neighborhoods due to traffic or roadwork.

Other traffic calming treatments, like narrower lanes, also encounter resistance. In Celebration Florida, (<https://ssti.us/2017/04/03/fire-codes-threaten-to-undo-urban-street-design/>) for example, fire officials argue for maintaining a 20-foot minimum clear width to maneuver, despite the city’s historically operating without wider roads. In our [recent post](https://ssti.us/2024/01/29/narrow-lanes-are-safer-but-they-can-be-extremely-difficult-to-build/) (<https://ssti.us/2024/01/29/narrow-lanes-are-safer-but-they-can-be-extremely-difficult-to-build/>) about the importance of narrow lanes for safety, we also discussed the need for road designers to consult with local emergency response officials. Their concerns can often be addressed by testing temporary road installations, revising fire codes, or shifting toward smaller vehicles.

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